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N° 18

COLLECTION · SELLERS

Selling on Your Own or With a Broker

DuProprio vs. a real estate broker — the real math, no myths

2026 EDITION

READ BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It offers general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. As every real estate situation is different, it is recommended that you consult the appropriate professionals before making any decision regarding a real estate transaction.

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DuProprio vs. a real estate broker — the real math, no myths

“Why pay a commission if I can sell on my own?” The question is legitimate, and deserves a real calculation rather than a slogan. Selling it yourself can suit some; for others, a broker's support brings in more than it costs.

This guide honestly compares the two options: what a broker really does, the real costs and risks of going “without an intermediary”, and how to decide based on your situation.

Each chapter ends with a lined “My notes” page to run YOUR calculation.

Sell on your own or with a broker? The right answer depends on your market, your time and your tolerance for risk. This guide honestly compares the two paths — a broker's real work, the costs and risks of going “without an intermediary”, and the calculation of the net in pocket.

Goal: decide with full knowledge, numbers and responsibilities in hand.

CHAPTER

What a broker really does

> *Seeing the full work behind the commission.*

- Set the right price (comparative analysis) and advise on the strategy.
- Prepare, photograph and market (Centris, the broker network, wide distribution).
- Screen buyers, arrange and manage the visits.
- Negotiate the offers and conditions in your interest.
- Handle the legal aspects (forms, seller's declaration, deadlines) and secure the transaction through to the notary.

The commission pays for all this work AND the network of buyers it gives access to.

Beyond the listing, a broker sets the right price, prepares the marketing, screens buyers, leads the negotiation and secures the legal aspects through to the notary. The commission pays for a full job — and a professional responsibility governed by the OACIQ.

> EMILIE'S TIP
>
> *The real question isn't “how much does a broker cost?” but “how much do they bring me, net, after commission?” A better sale price and a secured transaction often far outweigh the fees.*

CHAPTER

The costs and risks of going “without an intermediary”

> *Assessing what “selling on your own” really involves.*

Selling on your own isn't free or risk-free: the platform package, buying your own services (photos, appraisal), the time invested, and above all the risk of costly mistakes.

- The risk of mispricing (too high: it lingers; too low: a dead loss).
- Often less exposure to the network of brokers and their buyers.
- Direct negotiation, without an intermediary, often emotional.
- Legal risks: latent defects, a poorly completed seller's declaration, after-sale disputes.

Selling on your own is neither free nor risk-free: visibility packages, time, managing the visits and above all legal liability. A mistake in the promise to purchase or an omission in the seller's declaration can cost far more than a commission.

> EMILIE'S TIP
>
> *The most costly mistake of “selling on your own” is almost always the price: a few percent less on a house is often far more than the commission saved.*

CHAPTER

The real math, numbers in hand

> *Comparing the NET in pocket in each scenario.*

Compare the NET amount you take in in each case, not just the commission avoided:

- Broker scenario: sale price (often optimized) − commission = net A.
- On-your-own scenario: sale price (it's up to you to reach the right price) − platform and service fees − the value of your time − risk = net B.
- The difference depends mainly on your ability to get the best price by yourself.

Many sellers discover that a good broker gets a higher price that covers their commission — while sparing them the stress and the risk.

Compare the NET actually taken in in each scenario, not the commission in absolute value. A broker who gets a better price, faster and with less risk, can leave you as much — or more — in pocket as a poorly negotiated on-your-own sale.

> EMILIE'S TIP
>
> *Run the calculation in net terms, honestly, including the value of your time and the risk of error. It's the only comparison that means anything.*

CHAPTER

How to decide based on your situation

> *Choosing the option suited to YOUR case.*

Selling on your own can suit you if: you know the local market very well, your property is in high demand, you have the time, ease with negotiation and the rigour for the legal side. Otherwise, a broker's support reduces the risk and aims for a better net result.

There are also in-between formulas (à-la-carte services). The important thing: decide with full knowledge, with a real calculation, not a reflex.

Selling on your own can suit you if you know the local market very well, have time, are comfortable with the paperwork and negotiation, and accept the risk. When in doubt, or for a complex property (co-ownership, estate, separation), support quickly pays for itself.

> EMILIE'S TIP
>
> *Meet a broker before deciding, even if you lean toward “on your own”: you'll leave with at least a price analysis and a clear view of the market — and often with a better decision.*

CHAPTER

Selling on your own: the essential precautions

> *Reducing the risks if you go without a broker.*

Selling it yourself is possible, but some steps demand rigour to avoid trouble:

- Set a **realistic price** from real comparable sales.
- Properly complete the **seller's declaration**.
- Use **compliant documents** for the promise to purchase.
- Screen visitors and think about your **safety**.
- Have the legal side validated by a **notary**.

What you save in commission, you pay in time, risk and responsibility: to be assessed honestly.

If you sell on your own, at least lock down the essentials: a price backed by comparables, a rigorous seller's declaration, compliant documents, safety during visits, and legal validation by a notary. What you save in commission, you pay in time and risk: assess it honestly.

> EMILIE'S TIP
>
> *If you sell on your own, at least have the promise to purchase and the seller's declaration overseen by a professional. A poorly drafted clause or an omission can cost far more than a commission.*

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

> *Your next steps, concretely.*

This week

1. List the selling tasks and assess which ones I can take on.
2. Estimate the value of my time and my ease with negotiation.

Within 30 days

1. Run the net-in-pocket calculation for each scenario.
2. Meet a broker to get a price analysis.

Next

1. Decide with full knowledge, numbers in hand.

To decide

1. Calculate my estimated net in pocket in each scenario.
2. Assess my available time, my legal ease and the acceptable risk.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Commission: the broker's fees, paying for all the selling work.
- Net in pocket: the amount actually taken in after all costs.
- Seller's declaration: a key document to limit latent-defect disputes.
- À-la-carte services: in-between formulas between “on your own” and “full management”.
- Broker network: the pool of buyers accessible through a broker.

- Commission: the broker's compensation, in exchange for a full mandate.
- OACIQ: the body that governs brokers and protects the public.
- Net in pocket: the amount actually taken in after all costs.
- Seller's declaration: a form recording what the seller knows about the property.
- Legal liability: the risk borne by the seller who acts alone.

GOING FURTHER

Quiz — test your knowledge

1. A broker's commission pays for:

A) Nothing

B) A full job and access to a network of buyers

C) Only a sign

D) The Welcome Tax

2. The right question to ask is:

A) How much does a broker cost?

B) How much do they bring me net, after commission?

C) What colour of sign?

D) None

3. The most costly mistake of “selling on your own” is often:

A) The sign

B) The wrong price

C) The photos

D) The parking

4. Selling on your own carries a legal risk of:

A) Nothing

B) Latent defects and a poorly completed seller's declaration

C) Too many buyers

D) A hidden commission

5. The right comparison is:

A) The commission avoided only

B) The NET in pocket in each scenario

C) The asking price

D) The municipal assessment

6. Selling on your own can suit you if:

A) You don't know the market

B) You know the market, have the time and ease with legal and negotiation

C) You hate negotiating

D) You lack time

7. An in-between formula exists in the form of:

A) Nothing

B) À-la-carte services

C) A mandatory auction

D) Giving away the house

8. Before deciding, it's wise to:

A) Talk to no one

B) Meet a broker for a price analysis

C) Set the price at random

D) Copy the neighbour

Answer key

1. B — Price, marketing, visits, negotiation, legal (ch. 1).

2. B — You reason in net terms (ch. 1).

3. B — A few % less exceeds the commission (ch. 2).

4. B — Possible after-sale disputes (ch. 2).

5. B — You compare the net, time and risk included (ch. 3).

6. B — It depends on your skills and availability (ch. 4).

7. B — À-la-carte options exist (ch. 4).

8. B — You decide with full knowledge (ch. 4).

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Thank you for reading. May this guide help you decide with confidence, with all the information in hand.